Recognizing Racial Microaggressions

1. **Assuming Black, Indigenous & People of Color (BIPoC) to be foreign-born:** *Where are you from … What are you?…You speak English so well.*

2. **Attributing intelligence to a BIPoC:** *Wow, you are a scientist?!…You are so articulate!…How did you get so good at math?*

3. **Attributing interests or talents based on race:** *I'm surprised you like Country & Western music…You must be good at [stereotypes such as sports for Black people, math for Asian American people].*

4. **Mistaking identity:** *You look so much like Mariah Carey!…*Calling someone by another PoC's name.

5. **Misattributing:** Attributing a BIPoC's idea or proposal to someone else.

6. **Denying race-color difference:** *I don't think of you as Black. I'm colorblind…We're all equal in this group…There is only one race—the human race.*

7. **Assuming a BIPoC is dangerous, dishonest, or a sexual predator:** Clutching purse as BIPoC approaches…Store owner follows BIPoC around store….Crossing street to avoid BIPoC….Locking the car doors at a stop light….Leaving the elevator…*You people…*

8. **Denying racism:** *I'm not racist; I have several Black friends…Are you sure you were being followed in the store?…I didn't hear that….You're being overly sensitive…It was just a joke…*

9. **Equalizing life experiences and ignoring differential impact:** *The same thing happens to me…I don't think that song excludes anyone.*

10. **Assuming meritocracy and a level playing field, and that Whiteness doesn't play a role in success:** *I believe the most qualified person should get the job….Anyone can succeed here if they work hard enough—this is America!…He'll get the job because he's Black.*

11. **Assuming the values and communication styles of the dominant/White culture are normal/ideal:** *Why do you have to be so loud/angry?…She needs to dress more professionally.…You can't do your hair like that….Why do they give their children such weird first names?…I can't understand their English*

12. **Giving differential treatment/mistaking role:** BIPoC assumed to be a service worker, salesperson, or subordinate…White person assumed to be the boss….BIPoC is ignored at a store counter, given a less desirable table at a restaurant.

13. **Piling On:** *I'm so sorry you are discriminated against…It must be awful to be you…It's so unfair that everyone thinks Black women are angry.*

14. **Tears & Shame**: When called on having committed a microaggression, tearful expressions of denial, hurt, or shame that take focus away from the impact on the BIPoC.

Adapted by Halverson, C., Moore, R., and Williams, P., from Sue, D.W. (2010). *Microaggressions in Everyday Life: Race, Gender, and Sexual Orientation*; and from Sue, D. W., et. al. "Racial Microaggressions in Everyday Life," *American Psychologist* (May-June 2007), 271-286.